

CMS questionnaire and SCI Index

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CMS Indicators

Legislative Dimension: Manipulation of the Rules of the Game

SCI Indicator	Theoretical Mechanism	Survey Question(s)
L1: Consultation Exclusion	Bypassing public scrutiny through fast-tracking.	L_PROC (Item 1): Frequency of accelerated procedures to avoid debate. SC5: Perception of whose interests prevail in decisions.
L2: RIA Manipulation	Use of formalistic or fake evidence to justify laws.	L_PROC (Item 2): Formalism of impact assessments. L_PROC (Item 3): Direct authorship by lobbyists.
L3: Transparency Resistance	Refusal to regulate lobbying and executive conflicts.	L_LOBBY: Deliberate avoidance of lobbying regulations. A9/A10: Social acceptability of favors for MPs/Ministers.

Executive Dimension: Resource Distribution and Power

SCI Indicator	Theoretical Mechanism	Survey Question(s)
E1: Procurement Concentration	Rigging tenders to favor specific political-business circles.	E_PART (Item 2): Conditions written for specific firms. SC4: Management of public resources for small groups.
E2: Admin. Particularism	Selective and punitive application of state audits or permits.	E_PART (Item 1): Targeted audits to punish rivals. E_PART (Item 3): Bureaucratic bias for "our people." A12/A13: Personal victimization experiences.
E3: Impunity Track Record	De facto immunity for top-level political and economic elites.	J_CONTROL (Item 3): Blocking of investigations by the prosecution. A4 (O/S):

		Perceived corruption among Ministers/Party Leaders.
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Judicial Dimension: Control and Immunity

SCI Indicator	Theoretical Mechanism	Survey Question(s)
J1: Appointment Capture	Political takeover of judicial governance and high courts.	J_CONTROL (Item 1): Appointments based on loyalty rather than merit. A4 (G/H/I): Perceived corruption of judges/prosecutors.
J2: Functional Subordination	Courts favoring the executive branch in practice.	J_RESILIENCE: Ability of the system to protect citizens against elites. D51 (G/H): Trust in the judicial hierarchy.
J3: Case Rigging	Manipulation of registries and case allocation.	J_CONTROL (Item 2): Distribution of sensitive cases to "convenient" judges. J4: Perceived possibility to influence own case outcomes.

Strategic Capture and Contextual Indicators

Mechanism Category	Indicator Concept	Survey Question(s)
Foreign Influence	Degree of external leverage on domestic policy.	SC1/SC2: Influence of Russia, China, USA, EC. SC6: Foreign influence on energy/foreign policy via corruption.
Elite Loyalty	Conflict of interest favoring foreign actors.	SC3: Extent to which elites act in the interest of foreign governments.
Structural Barriers	Main obstacles to national independence and rule of law.	SC7: Ranking of capture vs. other threats like lack of accountability.

Preserved Corruption and Behavioral Metrics

Category	Indicator Concept	Survey Question(s)
Corruption Pressure	Frequency of direct and indirect bribe requests.	A12: Direct vs. showing expectation of favors.
Victimization	Actual incidence of giving bribes or services.	A13: Frequency of giving money, gifts, or services.
Social Norms	Acceptability of corruption in the public sector.	A8/A15: Personal readiness to pay a bribe if requested.
Institutional Trust	Baseline legitimacy of the administrative apparatus.	A4/D51: Multi-actor trust and corruption perception scales.

SCI indicators

CSI Indicator Table

Dimension	Code	Indicator Name	Mechanism Measured	Primary Data Source	Specific Metric / Calculation used for SCI
I. Legislative	L1	Consultation Exclusion	Bypassing public scrutiny to favor private interests.	OECD iREG / SIGMA	Inverse: "Stakeholder engagement in developing primary laws" (Score 0-4 normalized to 100-0).
<i>(Rules of the Game)</i>	L2	RIA Manipulation	Lack of evidence-based justification for laws.	OECD iREG / SIGMA	Inverse: "Quality of Regulatory Impact Assessment" (Score 0-4 normalized to 100-0).
	L3	Transparency Resistance	Refusal to regulate lobbying/conflicts of interest.	GRECO (5th Round)	Direct: % of <i>Non-Implemented</i> recommendations on top executive corruption prevention.
II. Executive	E1	Procurement Concentration	Rigging tenders for specific insiders.	Single Market Scoreboard	Direct: % of contracts awarded with a Single Bidder (Scaled: \$Raw\% \times 2\$, capped at 100).
<i>(Resource Distribution)</i>	E2	Admin. Particularism	Biased application of rules against rivals.	V-Dem (v2clrspct)	Inverse: "Rigorous and Impartial Public Administration" Index (0-1 converted to 100-0).
	E3	Impunity Track Record	Protection of elites from prosecution.	EU Rule of Law Report	Coded (0-100): Qualitative coding of "High-level corruption convictions" section (0=Robust, 100=Systemic Failure).
III. Judicial	J1	Appointment Capture	Political takeover of judicial governance.	V-Dem (v2juhcind)	Inverse: "High Court Independence" Index (0-1 converted to 100-0).
<i>(Control & Immunity)</i>	J2	Functional Subordination	Courts favoring the executive in practice.	EU Justice Scoreboard	Direct: % of public perceiving independence as "Bad/Very Bad" due

					to political pressure.
	J3	Case Rigging	Manipulation of case distribution.	GRECO / EU RoL	Coded (0-100): Qualitative assessment of "Allocation of cases" and "Ad-hoc transfers" (0=Random, 100=Discretionary).

Comparative Data Table: SCI vs. External Indicators

Dimension	Code	Indicator Name	BG	RO	HU	SK	PL	DE	SE	EE
I. Legislative	L1	Consultation Exclusion	45	42	88	74	62	12	8	9
<i>(Rules of the Game)</i>	L2	RIA Manipulation	55	58	92	65	50	15	10	12
	L3	Transparency Resistance	68	55	100	85	86	45	20	15
II. Executive	E1	Procurement Concentration	72	68	78	52	82	16	12	24
<i>(Resource Distribution)</i>	E2	Admin. Particularism	65	55	85	58	48	8	5	10
	E3	Impunity Track Record	75	50	100	60	60	0	0	5
III. Judicial	J1	Appointment Capture	50	45	90	55	88	5	2	5
<i>(Control & Immunity)</i>	J2	Functional Subordination	58	52	84	62	82	8	4	8
	J3	Case Rigging	75	40	100	50	75	0	0	0
SCI TOTAL		STATE CAPTURE SCORE	62.5	51.7	90.8	62.3	70.3	12.1	6.8	9.8
Context	CPI	Corruption Perception (2025)	40	45	40	48	53	77	80	76
<i>(External)</i>	WGI	Control of Corruption (Est.)	-0.3	-0.2	-0.3	+0.1	+0.6	+1.9	+2.0	+1.7
	GINI	Inequality Index (2024)	38.4	32.0 *	28.0	21.7	27.2 *	29.5	27.6	30.9
	GDP	Per Capita	66	77	76	75	78	116	111	79

		(PPS, EU=100)								
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**Note: GINI values for RO and PL are 2023 estimates as final 2024 Eurostat data for these specific countries was pending validation at the time of report generation.*

CAR report

The Integrated Diagnostic Framework: Executive Summary

National Capture Profile and Classification

The analysis begins by establishing a high-level classification of the state's institutional health. We use the overall State Capture Index (SCI) score to determine if the nation falls into the Systemic, Transitional, or Resilient group. This subsection highlights the "Diagnostic Gap" by comparing the formal institutional scores against the perceived legitimacy recorded in the CMS data. It identifies whether the state is experiencing legalized capture, where the outward appearance of the law remains intact while the internal mechanisms are functionally subordinated.

Corruption Pressure and Victimization Trends

This subsection synthesizes the atmospheric data from the CMS framework. It focuses on the longitudinal trends of corruption pressure and actual victimization rates found in blocks A12 and A13. By presenting these behavioral metrics alongside the macro-diagnostics, we establish the ground-level impact of state hollowing. This part of the summary serves as an immediate indicator of whether systemic capture at the top is manifesting as high-frequency petty bribery or more targeted administrative coercion at the bottom.

Methodological Integration: Bridging the Macro-Micro Gap

The Macro-Micro Cross-Walk and Triangulation

This subsection describes the technical logic of the integrated assessment. It explains how we align macro-indicators from SIGMA, GRECO, and the OECD with the micro-level survey responses. We detail the triangulation process where the macro-data provides the structural blueprint of the institutional framework while the CMS data provides the functional evidence of how those structures operate in practice. This section justifies the use of perception and experience data as a necessary validation tool for institutional diagnostics.

Normalization and Data Weighting Logic

We outline the mathematical approach used to merge different data types into a unified scoring system. This includes the normalization of macro-indicators from various international databases to a standardized 0–100 scale. We also explain the weighting assigned to CMS survey percentages to ensure they are comparable with institutional benchmarks.

This subsection ensures transparency in how the final integrated scores for each pillar are derived and interpreted across the different methodological layers.

The Legislative Pillar: Institutionalizing Exclusion

Rules of the Game: Macro-Institutional Indicators (SCI)

This subsection focuses on the structural manipulation of the legislative process. It includes data from the SCI framework such as Consultation Exclusion (L1) and RIA Manipulation (L2) sourced from OECD iREG and SIGMA PAR metrics. We also incorporate the Transparency Resistance (L3) indicator, which evaluates the non-implementation rates of GRECO 5th Round recommendations. These metrics provide a quantitative assessment of the state's formal commitment to inclusive and evidence-based lawmaking.

Procedural Exclusion and Lobbying: Micro-Survey Findings (CMS)

We validate the macro-indicators through the CMS L_PROC and L_LOBBY blocks. This subsection analyzes citizen perceptions regarding the frequency of accelerated "fast-track" procedures used to bypass public debate. It examines the perceived authorship of laws by private interest groups and the deliberate avoidance of lobbying regulations by political elites. By contrasting these survey results with the SCI scores, we demonstrate how procedural hollowing in the parliament leads to a measurable decline in legislative legitimacy.

The Executive Pillar: Resource Diversion and Administrative Particularism

Resource Distribution and Impunity: Macro-Institutional Indicators (SCI)

The analysis of the executive branch starts with the SCI's measures of resource control. This includes Procurement Concentration (E1) from the Single Market Scoreboard and Administrative Particularism (E2) from V-Dem and World Bank governance indicators. We also include the Impunity Track Record (E3), which is qualitatively coded from EU Rule of Law reports to measure the lack of high-level accountability. These indicators identify the structural points where state resources are most vulnerable to being channeled toward political-business networks.

Administrative Pressure and Favoritism: Micro-Survey Findings (CMS)

This subsection utilizes the CMS E_PART block and victimization metrics to confirm the macro-trends. We analyze responses concerning targeted audits used as political weapons and the prevalence of bureaucratic bias favoring those with the right connections. Question SC4 is used to measure public perception of how public resources and state enterprises are managed. This integration shows how the structural risks identified in the SCI manifest as direct corruption pressure and unfair competition for citizens and businesses.

The Judicial Pillar: Functional Subordination and the Immunity Shield

Institutional Hollowing: Macro-Institutional Indicators (SCI)

This subsection examines the top-down control of the legal system. From the SCI framework, we incorporate Appointment Capture (J1) and Functional Subordination (J2) indicators derived from the EU Justice Scoreboard and V-Dem data. We also assess Case Rigging (J3) through qualitative audits of judicial governance provided by GRECO. These metrics track the degree to which the judiciary has been structurally neutralized through the takeover of its governing bodies and the hollowing out of its independence.

Litigant Experience and Outcome Influence: Micro-Survey Findings (CMS)

We provide a ground-level check on the judiciary through the CMS J_CONTROL and J4 blocks. This subsection focuses on the experiences of individuals who have participated in court cases, measuring their belief in the possibility of influencing legal outcomes through bribes or connections. We also analyze the perceived frequency of distributing sensitive cases to "convenient" judges. This part of the report highlights the gap between formal judicial independence and the functional reality of a system that citizens perceive as serving elite interests.

Strategic Capture: The Geopolitical and Elite Dimension

Foreign Leverage and Corruptive Influence (CMS-Led)

This section shifts the focus toward the external drivers of institutional hollowing as identified in the CMS framework. We utilize indicators SC1 and SC2 to measure the perceived influence of foreign powers like Russia and China on domestic political decisions. This subsection analyzes how corruptive practices are seen as tools for influencing energy policy or NATO/EU membership decisions. This provides a geopolitical layer that explains why certain domestic institutional mechanisms might be deliberately weakened.

Elite Loyalty and Institutional Vulnerability (CMS-Led)

We examine the alignment of domestic elites with external interests using the SC3 and SC6 indicators. This subsection assesses the extent to which political and economic leaders are perceived as acting for foreign governments rather than the national interest. By linking these findings to the SCI's legislative and executive indicators, we identify the specific institutions most vulnerable to being used as conduits for strategic capture. This analysis reveals the "Elite Capture" component that often drives the internal colonization process.

Risk Forecasting and Policy Roadmap

Institutional Tipping Points and Crisis Indicators

The synthesis of the SCI and CMS data allows for the identification of critical thresholds where capture becomes irreversible without systemic shock. This subsection identifies

specific institutional weaknesses that represent the highest risk for state collapse or total democratic backsliding. We look for areas where high SCI scores for hollowing are matched by high CMS scores for public distrust, signaling a complete breakdown of the social contract in that specific sector.

Technical Reform Priorities and De-Colonization Strategy

The report concludes with a set of targeted policy recommendations. These are derived from the mechanism gaps identified in each pillar, focusing on technical solutions like the mandatory automation of judicial registries to address J3 risks or the tightening of RIA oversight to counter L2 manipulation. This roadmap emphasizes the need for procedural safeguards that remove human discretion from the state’s key functions, providing a clear path for restoring institutional integrity through verifiable reforms.

Sample report section

The Integrated Diagnostic Framework: Executive Summary

National Capture Profile and Classification

Based on the macro-institutional diagnostics of the State Capture Index, Bulgaria is classified as a Group 2 state characterized by Transitional and Fragmented Capture. With an overall institutional score of 65.6, the country exhibits a risk profile where institutional hollowing is not yet as legally locked-in as in systemic cases like Hungary, but remains significantly more volatile than resilient benchmarks like Estonia. The classification is driven primarily by intense risks in the executive and judicial dimensions, specifically in areas where human discretion has not been successfully removed from state processes. While formal legislative structures maintain a veneer of alignment with European standards, the underlying functional reality reveals a state apparatus that is frequently bypassed or instrumentalized for the benefit of specific political-economic networks.

The primary mechanism of capture in this profile is the diversion of public resources through concentrated procurement and administrative bias. The macro-data indicates that institutional colonization has moved beyond simple transactional bribery into a phase of strategic hollowing where public assets are managed with minimal competitive oversight. This classification suggests that while the state possesses the formal capacity for governance, its core functions are redirected toward maintaining a shield of impunity for elite actors while selectively applying rules to the broader population. The diagnostic baseline suggests a state in constant friction between its formal obligations to international frameworks and the informal demands of domestic patronage networks.

Indicator Code	State Capture Mechanism	Bulgaria Score (0-100)	Risk Intensity
L1	Consultation Exclusion	45	Moderate

L2	RIA Manipulation	55	Moderate
L3	Transparency Resistance	68	High
E1	Procurement Concentration	72	High
E2	Administrative Particularism	65	Moderate
E3	Impunity Track Record	75	High
J1	Appointment Capture	50	Moderate
J2	Functional Subordination	58	Moderate
J3	Case Rigging	75	High
	Overall institutional score	65,6	

Comparative Regional Benchmarking

The intensity of capture in Bulgaria is best understood through a comparative lens. When placed alongside systemic capture benchmarks and resilient institutional models, the Bulgarian profile reveals a specific "Transitional Gap." While the country has avoided the total legislative colonization seen in Group 1, it remains heavily exposed to the functional manipulation of its executive and judicial branches. This uneven distribution of risk distinguishes fragmented capture from the more uniform institutional hollowing found in high-capture regimes.

Dimension Average	Group 1 (Systemic: HU)	Group 2 (Bulgaria: BG)	Group 3 (Resilient: EE)
Legislative (L1-L3)	93.3	56.0	12.0
Executive (E1-E3)	87.7	70.7	13.0
Judicial (J1-J3)	91.3	61.0	4.3
Total SCI Score	90.8	65.6	13.7

Corruption Pressure and Victimization Trends (CMS Placeholders)

The institutional diagnosis of fragmented capture is validated on the ground through the experience of the population, which serves as the ultimate barometer for the effectiveness of the state's integrity systems. In the current assessment period, the Corruption Monitoring System (CMS) tracks the frequency with which citizens encounter direct and indirect pressure to participate in corrupt exchanges. While the State Capture Index identifies the structural vulnerabilities, the CMS victimization data reveals the extent to which these hollowing-out processes translate into actual costs for the average person.

[CMS PLACEHOLDER: Insert frequency of direct and indirect bribe requests from Block A12. Analysis should contrast the perceived breadth of corruption from A2 with actual victimization rates in A13 to determine the 'integrity gap' between public perception and personal experience.]

[CMS PLACEHOLDER: Insert data on personal readiness to pay (A15) and social acceptability of bribery (A8). This data will be used to analyze the normative resilience of the population against institutional colonization. High readiness scores despite low victimization would indicate a normalization of capture, whereas high victimization despite low social acceptability would suggest a predatory state environment.]

The Diagnostic Gap: Institutional Facade vs. Lived Reality

A critical component of this profile is the measurement of the diagnostic gap, which occurs when formal institutional performance metrics diverge from the qualitative experiences recorded in the national sample. The SCI framework identifies specific red flags in procurement and judicial registries, yet the population survey often provides a more nuanced view of whether these risks are perceived as systemic or incidental. If the SCI indicates high procedural hollowing while the CMS records relatively low victimization, the state is likely in a phase of legalized capture where the elite have successfully moved their extraction activities away from the public eye and into the realm of high-level administrative manipulation.

[CMS PLACEHOLDER: Insert trust levels from Block D51 and A4, specifically focusing on the disparity between trust in 'front-line' officials like teachers and 'high-level' actors like ministers and MPs. A wide trust gap between these categories would confirm the 'Elite Capture' hypothesis where the top of the institutional pyramid is seen as colonized while the administrative base remains relatively functional.]

[CMS PLACEHOLDER: Insert summary findings from Question SC7 regarding the perceived greatest obstacle to national independence. If the population ranks institutional capture higher than external threats or lack of transparency, it confirms that the hollowing out of the state is recognized as the primary systemic risk by the citizens themselves.]